

A

With adjectives

Prefixes, e.g. **un-**, **dis-**, **im-**, can be added to some adjectives to give the opposite meaning.

happy	unhappy
possible	impossible
regular	irregular

honest [tells the truth]	dishonest
correct [right✓]	incorrect
legal [allowed by law]	illegal

Dan used all the milk but said he didn't; he's very **dishonest**.

I got eight answers right, but two were **incorrect**.

It's **illegal** in the UK to ride a motorbike without a helmet.

B

un-

Of the prefixes above, **un-** is the most common, and appears in a number of adjectives.

This chair is incredibly **uncomfortable**.

It was **unnecessary** for them to wait for us.

Xerxes – that's a very **unusual** name. [different, not common or ordinary]

I won the game; it was completely **unexpected**. [I didn't think I was going to win]

Marsha's hat is **unbelievable**. [surprising because it is either very good or very bad]

We tried to open the door, but we **were unable to** get in. [could not]

I need to do more exercise; I'm very **unfit**. [not healthy and not in good condition]

Declan played well, and I thought he was **unlucky** to lose.

They're **unlikely** to get here before midday. [They probably won't get here before midday.]

The test was **unfair** because some of the students had more time to do it than others. [If something is *unfair*, it does not treat people equally.]

Language help

Adding a negative prefix does not usually change the pronunciation; the stress stays the same.
She was un'lucky. It's unbe'lievable. (NOT She was 'unlucky. It was 'unbelievable.)

C

With verbs

With some verbs, these prefixes can have particular meanings.

dis- [the opposite of something]	I disagree with the others. [don't agree / have the same opinion] The plane appeared in the sky, then it disappeared behind a cloud.
un- [the opposite of an action]	I couldn't unlock the door this morning. [open the door using a key; <i>opp lock</i>] We had to get undressed in the cold. [take off our clothes; <i>opp get dressed</i>] I unpacked the bags. [took everything out of the bags; <i>opp pack</i>]
over- [too much]	The bank overcharged me. [asked me to pay too much money]
mis- [do something incorrectly]	I misunderstood what he said; I'm afraid my English isn't very good. I misheard her. I thought she said <i>Rita</i> , not <i>Brita</i> .
re- [again]	The teacher has asked me to rewrite my essay.